

Eschrichtius robustus

Gray whale



Location North Pacific

Length 43–46 ft
(13–14.2 m)Weight 15–38½ tons
(14–35 tonnes)

Social unit Group

Status Least concern

Gray whales filter-feed like other baleen whales. Unusually, however, they also rely on diving to the shallow sea bed, scooping up huge mouthfuls of mud, and filtering worms, starfish, shrimps, and other small creatures with their short, coarse baleen. This whale's sounds include grunts, wails, moans, and clacking knocks, but the function of these sounds is little understood.

CONSERVATION

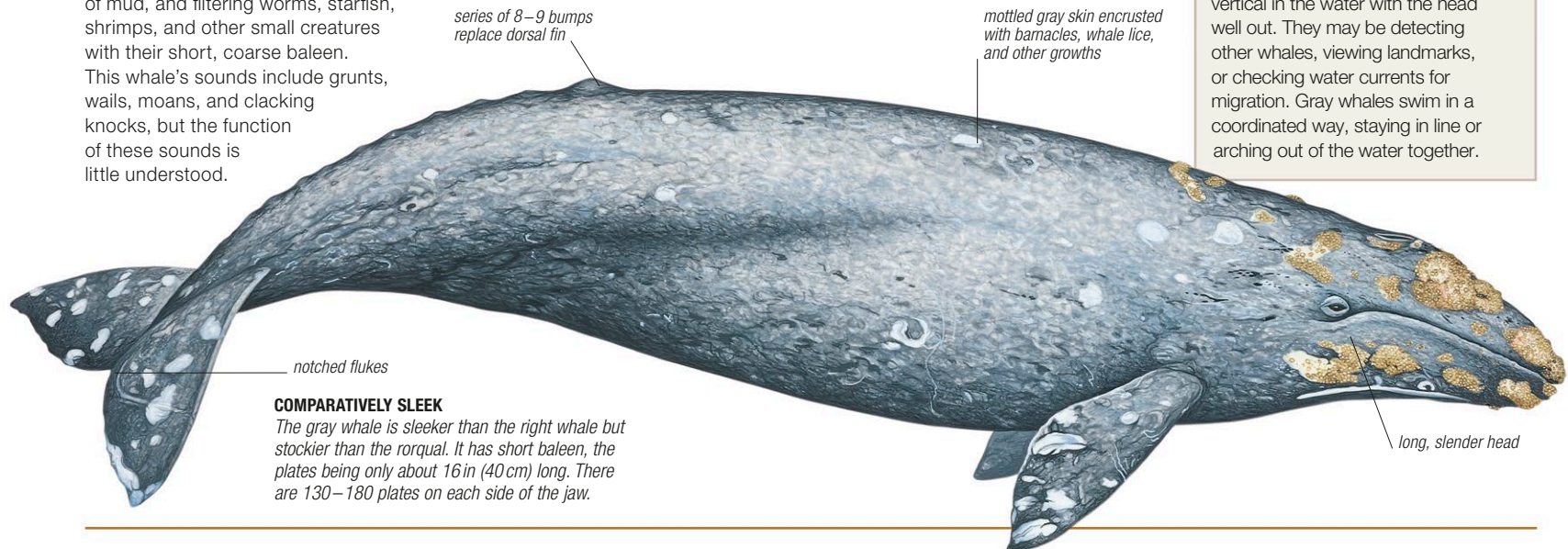


Gray whales feed near shore so they are accessible to watchers, especially in the east Pacific, though whale watchers are urged to keep at least 300 ft (90 m) from whales at all times. These whales migrate in groups of up to 10, north to the Arctic for summer feeding, and south to warm-water lagoons to rest and produce calves in winter. Populations in the east Pacific have risen since legal protection was introduced in 1946. However, west Pacific numbers are still low.

SPY-HOPPING



Many baleen whales, including the gray whale, "spy-hop," becoming vertical in the water with the head well out. They may be detecting other whales, viewing landmarks, or checking water currents for migration. Gray whales swim in a coordinated way, staying in line or arching out of the water together.



COMPARATIVELY SLEEK

The gray whale is sleeker than the right whale but stockier than the humpback. It has short baleen, the plates being only about 16 in (40 cm) long. There are 130–180 plates on each side of the jaw.

Eubalaena japonica

North Pacific right whale



Location Temperate and subpolar waters

Length 43–56 ft
(13–17 m)Weight 19³/₂₅ tons
(18 tonnes)

Social unit Variable

Status Endangered

The most endangered of the large whales, this massive whale is at risk from collisions with ships and from fishing equipment because it swims slowly, dives for only a few minutes, and feeds near the surface. It migrates to the far north or south in summer and returns to warmer, mid-latitude waters in winter, when the female produces one calf, 13–20 ft (4–6 m) long. Twin blowholes give a bushy, V-shaped blow. Sounds include flipper-slaps and breaching.

FILTER FEEDING



The North Pacific right whale feeds alone or in small groups, swimming with mouth open to filter plankton as water rams into its mouth. The narrow baleen plates, mainly blue-black but sometimes white, are up to 9¾ ft (3 m) long. They number 200–270 on each side of the characteristically down-curved upper jaw.

Balaena mysticetus

Bowhead whale



Location Arctic and subarctic waters

Length 59–66 ft
(18–20 m)Weight 98¼ tons
(100 tonnes)

Social unit Group

Status Least concern

The bowhead whale has a massive head, around one-third of its total weight. The bowhead stays near spreading polar ice all year, enduring weeks of darkness when it may echolocate to navigate between and under floes. It surface-skims with its mouth slightly agape. Shallow dives can last less than a minute, but deeper dives may last up to an hour. It can eat in midwater or even grub on the bottom. The newborn calf is 13–15 ft (4–4.5 m) long and is suckled for 5–6 months.



SMOOTH SURFACE

The mainly black body is clear of whale lice, barnacles, skin callosities, and similar growths.

BIGGEST BALEEN

The bowhead has the longest baleen of any whale. The brown- or blue-black baleen plates reach 16¼ ft (5 m) in length, with 230–360 baleen plates on each side of the strongly curved or "bowed" upper jaws (hence the name bowhead). This whale has no throat grooves and no dorsal fin either, giving its body surface a remarkably uncluttered appearance.

